Me-Commerce

If current times are the heydey of e-commerce, the next shift will be to Me-commerce. Another thing AR/ER allows you to do is get rid of the language barrier. Let's say a Japanese tourist is shopping in India, and wants to know all about the silk saris on display, he's going to have to ask in broken English, and get a reply in even more broken English, and so much is lost in translation that it's sometimes funny. However, thanks to AR being married to existing technology such as, say, RFID tags, perhaps he could just get all the details he needs, including where the saris were made and what makes them special. All he has to do is haggle on price. You'd also be thankful to AR when you travel to Japan and want something simple to eat that doesn't contain Octopus or Squid's feet, or whatever!

You can already use your webcam to see how different spectacle frames look on your face when buying those online. Now imagine clothes shopping online using the same technique. AR could show you outfits and how they'd fit you, and how a shirt and pant combo look on you, etc.

The biggest change that will happen is total personalisation of the whole e-commerce experience. You can already feel it happening. Browse around shopping sites for a keyboard and suddenly magically all you see are keyboard ads. Think of that but for everything, everywhere you go, and you get the idea about how your shopping experience - online, offline, in game, while on holiday, anywhere! - will be unique to you and you alone. That's what we mean by me-commerce.

The ARC4 developed by Applied Research Associates for the US military makes AR a tactical advantage

Military

Everything good usually comes from being developed by the military; that or the porn industry... Soldiers equipped for advanced warfare have been using AR for ages. Some would say simple night-vision optics could be considered AR, as the reality is pitch black, and the augmentation is the ability to see clearly. You can also consider head-mounted displays that soldiers use to tell them about terrain, identify buildings and give them accurate locations. Pretty soon every soldier will be able to see live satellite feeds overlaid in 3D on what he sees, and know exactly where the enemy is moving - even behind ridges or buildings - and thus be always aware of dangers. Like GPS, most of that technological capability will trickle into our everyday use.

Driving / Directions

Thanks to GPS, we're more aware of exactly where we are in our cars than anywhere else. So many of us already use GPS to navigate unfamiliar routes, but imagine subtle paths being marked right on to your windscreen! Instead of a voice telling you "Take the second right.", and then only muttering "Recalculating" as a way of saying "You went the wrong way dummy", GPS systems could just have a subtle arrow and say "Take that right".

If you are uncomfortable with something on your windscreen when driving, maybe it could just show on your phone when walking. Basically street view, but as you see it, and not in a clunky maps interface.

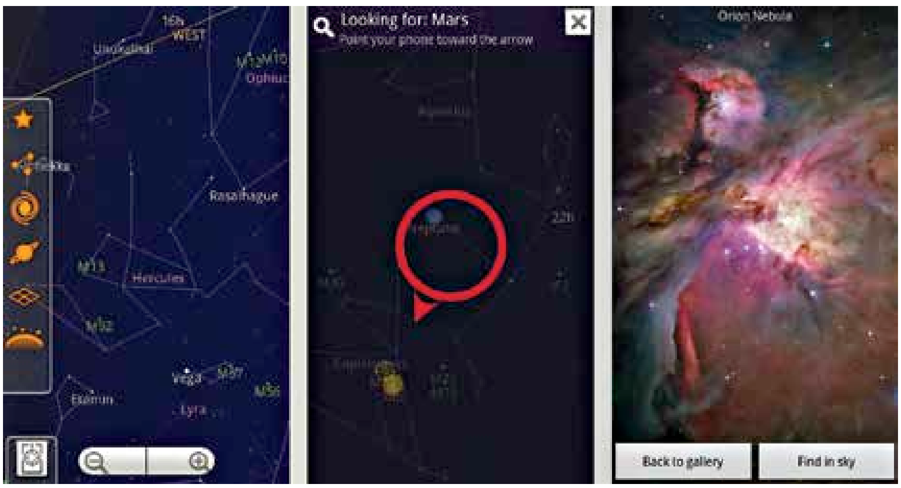
Medicine

Imagine a doctor walking in to see you and thanks to your medical history, already knowing all your past ailments, because depending on which part of the body he examines, he knows if you've had surgery, complained of pain, taken antibiotics, etc, to treat that part of the body.

Imagine overlaying in 3D the scans a doctor has performed on you, showing exactly where problem areas are, and thus being able to explain it to your relatives better. We will cut here, remove this tumour you can see here, etc.

Education

Education for everyone from medical students to engineers is just begging to be AR-ed. Visual aids are already increasing like never before in education, and you often hear people say that nothing grabs the attention of kids today like a screen. There's a reason for that - it's just easier to understand something with a video or a diagram. Now imagine medical students learning about parts of the body and being able to use their phones to see exactly where each part is, and be shown each vein and artery that's mentioned, etc. Engineering students could get 3D models of parts being shown in their textbooks, and the possibilities are only limited by our imaginations. Maybe this



Sky Map is a must have for star gazers the world over, educative and fun at the same time